two wickets standing at the end of play, we salvaged a notable draw.

'That was a brilliant and courageous effort,' said coach Dave Nosworthy in the changing room afterwards, 'and one day, AB and JP, I reckon you will do that again for the national team.' He was right.

This was my first overseas tour and I was loving every minute, enjoying the tough cricket against strong opponents, relishing the challenge posed by different conditions, enjoying the experience of playing in a country where 'summer' sometimes felt like an Antarctic winter.

Faf du Plessis, my friend from school and ever-present teammate, was on tour as well and I remember us being so determined to do well, speaking so often about how much we wanted to win the series. With each run and each practice session in the nets, we were evolving from schoolboys into professionals. It's difficult to exaggerate the value of national age-group overseas tours for youngsters making this transition.

The third and final match of the series, played in Chelmsford, was magnificently dominated by Faf. He made 177 in our innings of 646 and then took three wickets for 39 runs as England were beaten by an innings and 163 runs. The 'Test' series was won 2–0, but celebrations were postponed until after the one-day series that followed.

The opening ODI was played at Arundel and, chasing 268 to win, we appeared to have done enough when, in the penultimate over, I was caught behind off Liam Plunkett for 143 from 153 balls. Yet seven runs were still required and, after losing another wicket and allowing a few dot balls to slip by, we needed four from the last two balls. Aaron Phangiso, the slow left-arm bowler from Ga-Rankuwa, was facing; using a bat he had borrowed from me at the last minute, he struck the winning boundary.

Rain washed out the second and third one-day matches but we didn't mind and the squad could not have been happier as we flew home, with series wins in both the 'Tests' and the ODIs.

Life was good and it soon got even better. I was selected to play for Tukkies at the National Club Championships and Gerrit Deist, my friend